

Data for Profit

Carolyn Eisenbach, Ethan Gartica, Todd Marks, Alexander Pawuk, Anushree Zimmerman, Gray

Reyes, Nick McMichael, Paul Buczynski

Rochester Institute of Technology

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Dr. Ornelas

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Introduction

Whether we like it or not, personal data collection has become routine in everyday life. As long as individuals are using the internet in some capacity, it is highly probable that their personal data is being collected, stored, combined, and shared by companies and institutions, whether it be while using websites, social media platforms, online shopping services, or mobile apps (Richards & King, 2014; Singh, 2025). The data collected could include personally identifiable information (PII), browsing history, search activity, or location data, all of which can give others insight about a person's habits, interests, and behavior (Richards & King, 2014).

Organizations often claim that collecting this information will help to improve their services. The increasing scale of data collection has created serious concerns about privacy, confidentiality, transparency, and accountability (Richards & King, 2014; Singh, 2025). These concerns have become even more important since data misuse, unauthorized disclosures, and data breaches have moved from isolated incidents to systemic threats affecting not only individuals but also organizations (Federal Data Strategy Data Ethics Framework, n.d.).

As a result, personal data is no longer only a technical or legal issue but also an ethical one, as it seems that a line needs to be drawn on when organizations and companies may and should be allowed to collect data. This paper will examine how companies collect and profit from personal information through the sale of PII, personalized advertising, and location-based tracking, along with the ethical and legal implications of these practices. While data collection is often presented as useful and necessary in modern society, it becomes unethical when companies collect, share, or sell personal information without meaningful transparency, informed consent, and user control.

PII and Data Brokers

Websites and apps prolifically require users to provide personal information to use their services. PII is personal information that includes data in particularly 'sensitive' domains, such as health, employment, education, criminal justice, and personal finance. The US General Services Administration (GSA) defines it as being "information that can be used to distinguish or trace an individual's identity, either alone or when combined with other information that is linked or linkable to a specific individual" (GSA Rules of Behavior for Handling Personally Identifiable Information (PII) | GSA, n.d.). This type of information can reveal a great deal about an individual when enough data is combined. This information is being collected by companies for whatever use they see fit, regardless of whether users gave them informed consent. One of the main reasons companies collect data is to monetize it and profit at the expense of privacy. The sale of data and information to third-party clients means that information once thought to be a secret, or at least confined to just one area of the internet, is now available for purchase by any company seeking to acquire it.

Data can be collected in numerous ways, some of which are legal and require user consent, and others that involve collecting data without any user knowledge. Even when done legally, the clause that states they are allowed to sell the data is so buried in legal jargon that most users aren't even aware of what they are consenting to. In terms of the less legal ways, every person on the internet leaves a digital footprint that can be used to access information about their activities, including credit card transactions and financial records. A user's digital footprint is accessible to any website they may have visited, and to every action they may have taken. This information can then be collected and sold by data brokers, with users being none the wiser. Another concern with the sale of personal data is how easily it can end up in the wrong hands. Once companies share information with data brokers or third parties, it can spread far beyond its original purpose. This makes it easier for people to misuse that data for things like doxxing, identity theft, or other types of cybercrimes. Even information that seems

harmless, like where someone goes during the day or what they search online, can be combined to figure out who they are and where they live. Once that happens, people lose control over their own information, which can lead to harassment, scams, or other serious risks. This risk of misuse further strengthens the ethical concerns surrounding data collection, as it increases potential harm to individuals and demonstrates how easily personal information can be used in ways users never intended or agreed to. One of the most important pieces of information that gets collected and sold is geolocation data (DiPersio, 2024). Geolocation data can directly lead to the acquisition of PII, whether it is health records or a home address; others can then use this sensitive data to perform identity fraud or blackmail.

In one such instance of data collection, General Motors (GM), a company that produces over 6.1 million cars each year, was caught selling millions of its customers' driving and location data to third-party companies without their customers' consent (Sergiu Gatlan, 2026). This violation of data privacy led the Federal Trade Commission (FTC) to ban GM from selling any of its customers' data for five years and to require it to obtain customer consent before selling their data for twenty years. The ramifications of GM's sale of people's data were highly detrimental to many users. The data was sold to insurance agencies, which would then spike insurance rates and even refuse coverage to people living in certain areas (Sergiu Gatlan, 2026). This would then negatively affect people who could not control where they lived, afford higher insurance rates, or cover their bills without insurance coverage. These are incidents that would never have happened if GM had not sold people's geolocation data without their consent.

Even though there seem to be many negatives to selling user data online, many data broker companies claim that it has a proportional amount of positives as well. DiPersio (2024) remarks in her article that "they boast that their resources can boost business marketing campaign effectiveness, assist academic researchers searching for equitable solutions to a multitude of problems, and help the government manage public crises. Furthermore, they assert that they accomplish those goals while properly protecting individual privacy rights" (p. 40).

Even if some of these remarks were proven true, it raises an ethical question about whether it is okay to sell personal information, even if it leads to a positive outcome. In one instance, the government reported that agencies such as the FBI, IRS, and DHS had been buying data from data brokers to circumvent the need for warrants, court orders, and subpoenas (DiPersio, 2024). Buying this information could have led to the arrest of dangerous criminals without waiting for a warrant or worrying about the inability to obtain one. Even if it led to a positive outcome, the moral permissibility of this has not been investigated.

In a study by Margaret Crocco et al., teens were surveyed on their opinions of internet privacy, with a specific focus on search engines and social media platforms that collect and share user data. The study found that teens showed little interest in the topic and did not consider the collected data to affect them as individuals. The only teens concerned were those who worried that data being sold might harm their job prospects or insurance rates (Crocco et al., 2020). Many people do not care unless they are personally affected, even when there is a breach of online privacy. Using the basis of Kantian deontology and utilitarianism ethical theories, we will determine whether the ethical implications of a privacy breach depend on the public's overall view of it and whether it is less morally impermissible if the people who are affected by it do not care.

According to utilitarian ethics, the moral valence of an issue depends on whether it produces the greatest amount of good for the greatest number of people. In the case of GM selling customers' location data, a utilitarian would likely argue that the action was morally impermissible because it caused harm to many people and provided little clear benefit. People paid more for insurance or lost coverage altogether, while GM mainly profited from selling the information. There is no clear benefit to the action for the majority; in fact, it harms many users by increasing insurance rates and denying coverage to some. Nevertheless, when considering the teens in Margaret Crocco's study, utilitarianism becomes more complicated. Since many

students did not believe that collecting their information affected them personally, a utilitarian might argue that the practice is not morally wrong if it does not appear to cause harm.

Each instance of a privacy violation has its own considerations about whether it is morally good or bad. In a situation where a company illegally collected and sold millions of people's health data to other companies for targeted advertising (Toulas, 2026), utilitarianism would still ask whether the action is morally permissible, depending on whether it produces more overall good than harm. In that case, there is insufficient information to determine the answer. This shows why utilitarianism can be difficult to apply to data privacy issues and why it is useful to compare it with other ethical theories.

Kantian deontology is an ethical theory that determines whether something is morally wrong based on the action itself. To be a morally right action, it must adhere to all three moral formulas. It is much easier to say whether an action is morally right when considering deontology because its requirements are more objective. In the case of data brokers selling people's health data, this action is morally impermissible because it treats people only as tools for profit rather than as individuals with rights and autonomy. Since almost every instance of data brokering revolves around the intended company earning money, these companies use their users as a means to that end. Because this violates the second formula of deontology, selling data is morally wrong when companies do so without meaningful consent or when they view users solely as sources of profit.

Although PII is the clearest example of sensitive user data, it is not the only type of information that can threaten privacy. Other forms of data, especially those used for advertising and tracking, can raise similar concerns.

Personalized Advertising and Personalizable Data

At what point do companies overstep the ethical limit by infringing on our privacy in terms of personalizable data by selling our data for profit, and at what point does that limit stand?

Personalizable data includes browsing history, purchase history, search history, the advertisements a user clicks on, and any other data used for personalized advertising. Companies collect this information to learn more about users and deliver targeted ads. Although this data may not include a person's name, it can still reveal significant information about that person's habits, interests, and behaviors. For example, a company may be able to determine whether an individual has been searching for textbooks, applying for internships, or shopping for concert tickets. Companies often sell this information because it increases advertising effectiveness and generates profit. The problem is that many people do not fully know what is being collected or where it is shared. At a certain point, the use of this data ceases to be helpful and becomes invasive. Companies cross an ethical boundary when they collect or sell personalizable data without giving users a clear choice or meaningful control over it.

This type of data is collected through a variety of technologies. The most common method is through websites' cookies, which are small files stored in a browser. Some cookies are necessary for a website to work, such as remembering login information or keeping items in the cart. Others are tracking cookies that record which pages a user visits, which links they select, and how long they remain on each page. Websites and applications may also use tracking pixels and device fingerprinting. A tracking pixel is an invisible image embedded in a webpage or email that notifies a company when a user accesses the page or opens the email. Device fingerprinting identifies a specific device by collecting information such as browser type, screen size, operating system, and approximate location. Unlike cookies, device fingerprinting can continue to identify users even after browser data has been cleared.

Applications can collect additional information, including search history, purchase history, viewing habits, and the amount of time spent using the application. Some applications can also access approximate location, contact lists, or other information stored on a device. Companies frequently combine this information with data from data brokers, businesses that buy and sell consumer information. One company may know what a user searched for, while another may know what was bought. When that information is combined, it creates a much more detailed profile.

These profiles are valuable because they allow companies to predict user behavior. For example, a student who searches for laptops, visits university websites, and researches cybersecurity internships may begin receiving advertisements for computer companies, study tools, training programs, or internship websites. Although this information may not be directly tied to a person's name, it remains closely connected to that person's behavior. Over time, that profile becomes more detailed and accurate. A company may not know exactly who the individual is, but it can know enough to predict their habits and influence their decisions.

The collection and use of personalizable data raises both legal and ethical concerns. Laws such as the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) were created to protect personal information by requiring companies to be transparent about what data they collect and how they will use it. Under the GDPR, companies may process data when necessary to provide a service the user requested, such as recommending music or movies on a streaming platform. When the same information is used for targeted advertising, companies are generally expected to obtain separate and explicit consent.

Despite these legal protections, many companies still rely on privacy policies that are long, confusing, and easy to ignore. As a result, users often agree to data collection without fully understanding what it entails. Someone may reasonably expect a website to remember previous purchases to make recommendations. However, the same person may not expect the company to sell that information to advertisers or data brokers. When personal information is

moved from one context to another without the user's knowledge, the original expectations of privacy are broken. This is especially true when browsing history or purchase history is shared with third parties whose only purpose is to generate advertising revenue.

Research has shown that consumers are more likely to share personal information when disclosure is presented as the default option rather than a deliberate choice. This tendency is one reason the GDPR requires "privacy by default," meaning that companies must collect only the minimum amount of data unless a user actively chooses otherwise (Nissenbaum, 2004).

Companies often justify collecting personalizable data by arguing that it creates a better user experience. Rather than displaying the same advertisements to everyone, companies use the information they have collected to determine which advertisements are most likely to interest a specific user. A person who has recently looked at laptops may start seeing ads for computer companies or school supplies, while someone who purchases running shoes may later see ads for fitness products. According to Sosin (2025), this process is intended to "serve ads that align with each user's interest" ("What is Personalized Advertising?").

From a business perspective, this system is effective because people are more likely to click on advertisements that match their interests. Personalized advertising, therefore, increases sales and generates higher profits. Sosin (2025) also states that personalized advertising "create a better experience for consumers and better returns for advertisers" ("Key points of personalized advertising").

The ethical concern grows as advertising advances. Modern systems increasingly rely on artificial intelligence to predict not only what users may want, but also which message is most likely to persuade them. These systems can adjust advertisements based on a person's behavior, emotional state, and individual vulnerabilities. As a result, advertising begins to move beyond simple personalization and towards manipulation. Hyper-personalized systems can exploit users' "epistemic blind spots" (LeBrun, 2025, "Abstract") or areas where they are more vulnerable to misleading or persuasive messages. At that point, personalized advertising no

longer functions only as a recommendation. It becomes a way of influencing behavior without the user fully realizing it.

Utilitarianism assesses whether the overall benefits outweigh the harms. Companies argue that collecting personalized data helps users by providing more relevant recommendations and enabling many online services to remain free. A student seeking an internship may appreciate seeing job postings rather than random ads. Regardless, there are clear downsides. Constant tracking can make people feel like they are being watched, and there is always the risk that data could be leaked or misused. Research also found that people remain uneasy about sharing their information, even when companies promise that the data will be used only to improve service. One study found that consumers are generally reluctant to disclose personal information, regardless of whether personalization is used for advertising or services (M. Leszczynska & D. Baltag, 2024). From a utilitarian perspective, the ethical line is crossed when the loss of privacy and trust outweighs the convenience people receive.

Deontology focuses less on the outcome and more on whether the action itself is right or wrong. Under this view, people should be treated only as a way for companies to make money. When companies collect and sell data without making the process clear, they are using users as a means to an end. Even if personalized ads make a website better or help keep it free, that does not make the practice ethical if people do not truly understand what is happening. Many privacy policies are so long and confusing that most users simply click “accept” without reading them. In that case, the company may have legal permission, but the agreement is not genuine.

While utilitarianism and deontology approach the issue differently, they lead to a similar conclusion. Both suggest that companies cross the ethical limit when people no longer have real knowledge of, meaningful choice over, or control over how their information is used. Deontology offers a clearer standard because it focuses directly on whether companies respect the user’s autonomy and consent.

Location data raises many of the same concerns as personalizable data, but it can reveal even more. Rather than showing what a person searches for or purchases, location tracking can show where a person lives, works, shops, and spends time.

Location Tracking and Privacy

How and when should companies or governments be able to gather data based on location, and to what extent, if there is one, is acceptable?

Location data includes frequently visited areas, home addresses, workplace addresses, and any other places people have been while a device was connected to the internet.

Companies gather this information through multiple methods. This could mean using the strength of the connection to GPS satellites, cell towers, or Wi-Fi access points to calculate distance to them; using a device's Bluetooth signals; or using the area identified by a device's IP address to determine the device's location. Users may also share location data themselves by tagging places on social media, setting a home address in a mapping application, or clicking a "share location" button.

There are also some legitimate and beneficial uses of location data. Navigation applications rely on it to provide directions and traffic updates. Parents may use location sharing to know whether a child arrived home safely, and emergency services can use it to locate someone who is injured or in danger. Police may also use location records to investigate crimes or find missing persons. During natural disasters, government and rescue organizations may rely on location data to identify people trapped or areas that need the most help. Because of these uses, the ethical issue is not whether location data should ever be collected, but rather who has access to it, how long it is stored, and whether the person knowingly agreed to share it.

This location data can help companies understand users' interests, habits, and demographics, enabling them to advertise more effectively. Companies and stores can also set up advertisements for themselves as notifications sent to people within a certain geographic

range. This form of personalized, targeted marketing can be performed by an algorithm fed location data collected by companies specializing in location-based marketing.

Location data can also reveal much more than where a person has been. If someone regularly visits the same doctor's office, church, political event, or neighborhood, that pattern can reveal details about a person's health, religion, beliefs, or financial situation (Keegan & Ng, 2021). Even when a company removes a person's name, location records are often still easy to trace back to that person because most people have recognizable routines. Knowing where a person spends the night and where they go during the day is often enough to identify them.

One example of this involves the app Life360. It is marketed as a safety tool that allows families to see each other's locations in real time. However, reports found that the company sold precise location data from its users to third-party data brokers. Those companies could then use the information to learn where people lived, worked, shopped, or spent time. Many users believed they were sharing their locations only with family members and did not realize that the information was also being shared with third-party companies. Nevertheless, Life360 later stated that it had changed some of its data-sharing practices and argued that users could manage privacy settings within the app. Even with those changes, the example still shows how location tracking can become unethical when users do not fully understand where their information is going (Keegan & Ng, 2021).

Looking at the issue through utilitarianism evaluates the moral valence of an action based on whether it produces the greatest overall benefits. Collecting location data can sometimes have positive uses. Search engines may use it to recommend nearby stores or services that are more useful to a person or help police investigate a crime.

Utilitarianism also requires considering the harms. Constant tracking can make people feel watched, reduce privacy, and expose sensitive information. When companies collect and sell location data primarily to make money, the harms often outweigh the benefits.

Deontology reaches a stronger conclusion because it focuses on whether the action itself respects a person's privacy and autonomy. Companies that collect and sell location information often treat users solely as data sources to improve advertisements or increase profits. This treats people as a means to an end rather than respecting their ability to decide what happens to their information. Although both utilitarianism and deontology raise concerns about location tracking, deontology is easier to apply because it reaches a clearer conclusion: a person's movements and routines should not be treated by companies as a product.

Solutions and Privacy Protections

Companies typically collect PII, personal data, and location history with minimal oversight. These practices often occur without meaningful consent, so the next question is what should be done to prevent that from continuing.

Current privacy laws do not do enough to stop companies from misusing personal information. Even when a company is caught collecting or selling data without permission, the punishment is often small and does not prevent the same thing from happening again. If companies are going to continue using personal data, there need to be clearer limits on what they may collect and how they may use it.

One solution is to require companies to collect only the information necessary for a service to function. A navigation app may need a person's location while it is being used, but it should not continue storing that information or sell it later. A shopping website may need to remember what a person purchased, but it should not automatically share that information with advertisers. Companies should explain exactly what they are collecting and obtain permission before using it for any purpose.

Some governments have already begun to move in this direction. The General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) gives users more control by requiring companies to explain what information they collect and allowing people to opt out of certain types of tracking (Wolford,

2025). It also allows users to request a copy of their information or have it deleted. The California Consumer Privacy Act provides similar protections in the United States.

In the United States, the FTC has also investigated companies that collect or sell personal information without properly informing users. Still, the FTC can usually act only after harm has occurred, which is why many people believe stronger laws are necessary.

These laws still have limits. Many people do not know that these protections exist, and companies often make privacy settings difficult to find or understand. In addition, laws such as the GDPR apply only in certain countries, while the internet enables companies to collect information across national borders. This makes privacy laws difficult to enforce.

There should also be severe consequences for companies that misuse personal information. Large businesses often make more money from selling data than they lose from a fine. This has led critics to argue that current penalties are often treated as a cost of doing business rather than as a meaningful deterrent (Consumer Privacy, n.d.). As a result, current punishments do not always change company behavior.

Another useful protection is the “right to be forgotten,” which allows people to request that a company erase outdated information that is no longer needed. A person who used an app years ago should not have their old searches, purchases, or location history stored forever.

Privacy organizations such as the Electronic Privacy Information Center argue that privacy is a fundamental right and that people should have greater control over how companies collect, store, and sell their information (Consumer Privacy, n.d.). The organization believes that users should be able to make a real choice about what they share and should not have to give up large amounts of personal information simply to use common websites and apps. Other groups, such as the Electronic Frontier Foundation, have also argued that companies should collect less information in the first place and that users should have stronger control over how their data is stored and shared.

There are also actions individuals can take. People can adjust privacy settings, reject unnecessary cookies, turn off location sharing when not needed, and be more selective about which applications they download. Although their choice cannot completely stop data collection, they can reduce the amount of information companies can gather.

A stronger response to these issues requires more than new technology. It requires a different view of privacy itself. Personal information should not be treated as something companies automatically own once it is collected. Instead, people should remain in control of what is shared, who can use it, and when that access should end.

Conclusion

In the end, personal data collection is no longer just a normal part of being online. It has become a real ethical problem. Companies can gather large amounts of information about individuals and use it in ways that most people cannot fully comprehend or meaningfully control, like PII, personalized advertising, and location-based tracking (DiPersio, 2024; Richards & King, 2014). While those practices are often defended by the companies as necessary for convenience or to improve services, they also raise serious concerns about privacy, confidentiality, transparency, and accountability (Richards & King, 2014; Singh, 2025). As our paper's sections have shown, these issues can affect people in practical ways, ranging from targeted manipulation and unfair profiling to the misuse of sensitive personal and location-based information (Sergiu Gatlan, 2026; Sosin, 2025). For that reason, the line is crossed when individuals lose meaningful knowledge of, choice over, and control of their own information. Thus, if companies and institutions truly want to benefit from the use of personal data, they must accept responsibility for handling it in ways that respect people's rights and the consent associated with that data. Protecting privacy will therefore require stronger laws, clearer consent, and a greater willingness to treat personal information as something people own rather

than something companies are free to sell. These issues are not distant or theoretical; they directly affect how individuals interact with technology every day.

For Rochester Institute of Technology students, these issues are important because much of student life depends on digital systems. Students use websites, apps, and online services for classes, jobs, housing, transportation, and communication every day. As a result, they are directly affected by the collection and sale of personal information. The same students whose data is being collected today may later work for companies that design these systems. Because of that, RIT students are in a position to think not only about how these systems affect them now, but also about how they should be designed and regulated in the future.

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Written Paper Contributors

Alexander Pawuk: Introduction, Conclusion, APA Citations, Formatting

Anushree Zimmerman: Topic 1 Content

Ethan Gartica: Minor Revisions/Editing

Gray Reyes: Topic 2, 3, 4, Case Study, and Editing

Todd Marks: Topic 3 Content